



opportunity with both hands. He finished the match with 350 runs, the highest aggregate by a batter in a Duleep Trophy match, but his first-innings epic of 270 from 334 balls was truly defining, ensuring that East Zone effectively had the title wrapped up by stumps on Day 2.

The 28-year-old can often monopolise a highlights package when he is on song, but what stood out in Chennai was what would be missing from one as well. There was a roundedness to his approach, developed through practice, that shone through in the moments he chose to soak up pressure and those when he chose to put it back on the South Zone bowlers. Early on the first afternoon, with precious little assistance on offer, the South Zone pace attack opted for the short-ball strategy, and Kishan channelled all of his restraint into letting each one go, knowing that the quicks would eventually tire and provide scoring opportunities. Similarly, he parked his aggressive instincts to one side on the second morning, choosing to battle through a testing phase with

the second new ball despite being well past his century at the time.

When the scoring opportunities came through errors in line or length, he was quick to send them to the fence, and he showed relish in repeatedly dumping spinners Tripurana Vijay and Shreyas Gopal down the ground. By the time he had notched up his second First-Class double ton, his side had 708 on the board and as good a chance as any of walking away with the trophy.

His South Zone counterpart Tilak may not have walked away with a winner's medal, but he did leave with the Player of the Series award as a reward for 266 hard-fought runs for just one dismissal across the three innings he played.

Having dug his side out of a hole with a century and fifty in the semifinal, he found himself at the crease facing a Sisyphean effort on the third afternoon but continued to grind away nonetheless.

After his semifinal heroics, the Indian T20I vice-captain had declared that red-ball cricket was "in his

Evolving: Ishan Kishan's 270 was the headline act, but the manner of his marathon innings offered a deeper glimpse of his evolution in red-ball cricket.

blood," and he continued to evidence the statement with a 99 that dragged South Zone into the fourth day.

The Hyderabad batter carried an unhurried quality to his knock, taking relish in each ball doggedly defended to extend his stay at the crease, while sprinkling his innings with the odd boundary, particularly a pair of handsome drives through the onside of Mohammed Shami.

Captaincy test

With a docile pitch and the scorching Chennai heat, the match also provided an examination of both players' tactical acumen, and it was Kishan who acquitted himself better. He opted to use his pacers in short bursts to avoid sapping them of energy, with the inexperienced pair of Qureshi and Shikhar Mohan holding up the other end.